



The Mona Lisa

From the 1460s onward, oil paintings became increasingly popular in Italy, and Leonardo mainly painted in oils throughout his career.

In the early 1500s, Leonardo was juggling several different projects at once, including a commission to paint a woman's portrait. Who was this woman? Vasari was not in doubt, stating that "Leonardo undertook to paint for Francesco del Giocondo a portrait of Mona Lisa, his wife."



Such was Leonardo's reputation that he could have chosen to paint anyone—even the wealthiest or most aristocratic women. Lisa del Giocondo

was neither. So why did he agree to paint her?